

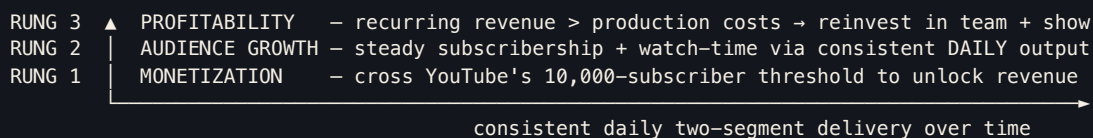


06 – Launch Roadmap, Metrics & Operations

*The phased plan to go from zero to a sustainable, owned-audience media business — with the KPIs that tell us it's working. The plan: **start lean and deliberate, grow the audience while building the team, raise production value over time.***

The path to success (the escalating scale)

Success is measured on a three-rung ladder. Each rung funds the next.



The whole strategy in one line: *Show up every day with two segments, let the clip engine compound watch-time and subscribers to clear 10k (Rung 1), keep the daily cadence to grow the audience (Rung 2), then scale until recurring revenue beats production cost (Rung 3) — and reinvest the surplus into team and production value.*

RUNG	THE MILESTONE	WHAT "DONE" LOOKS LIKE	WHAT IT UNLOCKS
1 — Monetization	10,000 YouTube subscribers (+ watch-hours for YPP)	Eligible for YouTube Partner Program; ad + membership revenue switches on	First real dollars; proof the format works
2 — Audience growth	Steady week-over-week subscriber + watch-time growth	Daily two-segment cadence held; clip engine compounding; email list climbing	Negotiating leverage for guests + sponsors
3 — Profitability	Recurring revenue > production cost	Membership + ads + sponsorship cover the operation with surplus	Reinvest in team, studio, and an expanded slate

Phased roadmap (mapped to the rungs)

Phase 0 – Foundation (Weeks 1–4) · *Build the rails, stay lean*

- Lock **brand system**: name treatment, logo, color, typography, set + lower-thirds, segment + clip templates (07).
- Ship the **landing page** (04, Phase 0) with email capture **live** — start the list before the show exists.
- Stand up channels: YouTube, IG, Substack, LinkedIn (consistent handles + art).
- Stand up the **lean production kit** + live pipeline; **test-run both segments** privately.
- **Bank 3–4 evergreen Evening Shows** (Tier 1 guests). Never launch empty.
- Define the **clip pipeline** (who edits, turnaround SLA, templates).
- **Exit criteria**: brand done, kit reliable, reserve episodes in the can, list capturing signups, calendar built.

Phase 1 – Launch & prove the daily format (Weeks 5–12) · *toward Rung 1*

- Go public with the **daily two-segment format**: ☀️ *Lunch Break Live* (10 min) + 🌙 *The Evening Show* (20 min), Mon–Fri.
- Weekly column + newsletter live on Substack; daily Read note from the Live take.
- Clip engine running: **≥6 clips/day** within 24–48 hrs.
- MVP site live (Home, /watch, /read, /join, /schedule).
- **Goal**: hold the daily cadence and drive toward **10,000 YouTube subscribers (Rung 1)**.
- **Exit criteria**: daily cadence held 6+ weeks; clip→subscribe funnel measurable; **YPP threshold crossed → monetization on**.

Phase 2 – Grow the audience & build the team (Months 4–8) · *Rung 2*

- Climb the **guest ladder** to Tier 2–3 (05); launch first **themed series**.
- Add monthly tentpoles: **Big Interview, State of the Unions, Town Hall, Roundtable**.
- **First key hires** (producer, editor) so the show ships daily without the host doing logistics.
- **Raise production value**: live producer/switcher, second camera, audio/lighting upgrade, graphics package (07, Phase 2).
- Site Phase 2 (guest directory, segments, search, transcripts, member gating); optimize the email funnel.
- First **sponsorship** conversations.
- **Exit criteria**: steady week-over-week subscriber + watch-time growth; paid conversion trending to target; a marquee guest booked.

Phase 3 – Reach profitability & scale the slate (Months 9–18) • *Rung 3*

- **Tier 4 marquee guests**; news-making interviews.
- Multiple revenue lines active (membership, ads, sponsorship, events); migrate to **owned billing** if the member base justifies it.
- **Dedicated studio**, multi-cam, motion-graphics, on-site marquee shoots (07, Phase 3).
- **Expand the slate** (new segments/series) funded by surplus.
- **Exit criteria: recurring revenue > production cost** with surplus reinvested; diversified revenue; a brand marquee guests seek out.

KPI targets by phase (illustrative – calibrate to actuals)

METRIC	PHASE 1 (→ RUNG 1)	PHASE 2 (RUNG 2)	PHASE 3 (RUNG 3)
YouTube subscribers	10k (monetization gate)	50k	150k+
YouTube watch-hours (rolling 12-mo)	4k+ (YPP gate)	growing	sustained
Engaged email subscribers (owned north star)	5k	25k	75k+
Paid members	100	1,000	4,000+
Avg. segment completion	40%	45%	50%
Clip → subscribe conversion	establish baseline	+25%	+50%
Newsletter open rate	45%	45%+	45%+
Revenue vs. production cost	seed / below	approaching parity	above (profitable)

Treat these as *direction and ratios*, not promises. Two disciplines decide everything: **(1) did we ship both segments today?** and **(2) is the subscriber/watch-time line going up and to the right every week?**

OKR example (the launch quarter – driving toward Rung 1)

Objective: Cross YouTube's monetization threshold by proving a reliable, must-watch daily two-segment show.

- **KR1:** Reach **10,000 YouTube subscribers** + the watch-hours needed for YPP.
- **KR2:** Deliver both daily segments (☀️ Lunch Break Live + 🌙 Evening Show) Mon–Fri with **100% on-cadence delivery** (no missed days).
- **KR3:** Ship **≥6 clips/day** within 48 hrs and grow engaged email subscribers from X → Y.
- **KR4:** Publish 12 columns + 12 newsletters on cadence and book/air ≥2 Tier-2 guests.

Team & roles (lean start → scale)

ROLE	PHASE	RESPONSIBILITY
Host / EP (Charles Blow)	All	On-camera, editorial voice, columns, marquee booking
Showrunner / Producer	P0	Calendar, guest booking, run of show, the engine
Video editor(s)	P0	Long-form + clip pipeline
Social/community manager	P1	Daily posting, engagement, Stories, community
Writer/researcher	P1	Prep docs, show notes, segment research, transcripts
Web/product (contract→FT)	P0–P2	Site build & funnel optimization
Growth/partnerships	P2	Sponsorships, cross-promo, events

Start with Blow + a showrunner + an editor + a contract web dev. Add the social manager and writer as cadence demands. Don't over-hire before the cadence is proven.

Budget buckets (relative priority, not absolute \$)

1. **Production** (camera/audio/lighting/set or studio rental) — the quality bar.
2. **Editing** (the clip engine — highest-leverage spend for growth).
3. **Web/tech** (site + email/membership tooling).
4. **Paid acquisition** (small, targeted — retarget clip-watchers to subscribe).

5. **Guest/travel** (occasional, for marquee bookings).

Highest ROI early dollars: **editing/clips** (drives discovery) and **email tooling** (captures it).

Risks & mitigations

RISK	MITIGATION
Cadence collapse (burnout/inconsistency)	Batch-and-bank; evergreen reserve; sustainable not heroic schedule
Platform dependence (algorithm/policy shift)	Owned email + membership is the hedge; multi-platform presence
Guest pipeline dries up	The ladder + book-tour pipeline + series packaging keep it full
Audience without revenue	Membership live from day one; don't wait to monetize trust
Brand dilution / chasing virality	Editorial guardrails; trust is the moat; "What Now?" discipline
Over-hiring early	Lean core team; add roles only as cadence proves out

The one-sentence operating plan

Film one great conversation a week, atomize it into a column + a newsletter + a dozen clips, point every platform at the email list, climb the guest ladder as the audience grows, and sell a membership to the trust you build.